Somebody could call me a troll for having an opinion. But I was a banker who had a million-dollar salary. Somebody could call me a troll, but that doesn't make me a troll.

The BJP attributes such importance to its digital work that when Amit Shah, as BJP president, was asked why he thought Modi had won his first national election in 2014, he responded by listing three reasons: the support of rural Indians, the support of Adivasis, Dalits and OBCs, and the party's work on cyber communications. Speaking to a convention of the BJP's Social Media Workers at Kota in September 2018, he declared that the work of the 'cyber-yoddhas' (cyber-warriors) and 'young workers' was the 'most important' factor behind the victory. A 'small social media cartoon', Shah argued, could often have bigger public impact than a big leader 'shouting his throat out' in a speech. The party's cyber yoddhas, in his view, had the 'ability to change the atmosphere of the whole election campaign'.[71]

Shah illustrated his point by recalling an incident to do with fake news and WhatsApp groups during the 2017 UP assembly poll campaign. The UP BJP, he said, had created WhatsApp groups that included 32 lakh members ahead of the election. This was done so the party could push its own political narrative through the social network. He said of the WhatsApp groups, 'Every morning at 8 a.m., they sent a message, *Satya Jaaniye* [Know the Truth]. Whatever newspapers used to print wrong news about the BJP, their truth was put on WhatsApp. It used to go viral. Whichever paper had printed this, social media volunteers and public also would attack it. They would ask, why did you print such a lie? Print the truth. Your job is to print the truth. So, they [newspapers] got scared and gradually became neutral type. It [social media] has such power.'

One day, a boy on the social media team did some chalaakee (cleverness), said Shah. He posted a fake message on WhatsApp saying Akhilesh Yadav had slapped his father Mulayam Singh Yadav. 'He had not slapped him,' said Shah. 'Netaji and Akhileshji were 600 kilometres apart. But he put it. The state social media team, without understanding it, circulated it below also. It spread everywhere. By 10 a.m., I started getting lots of calls: "Bhai Sahab, you know